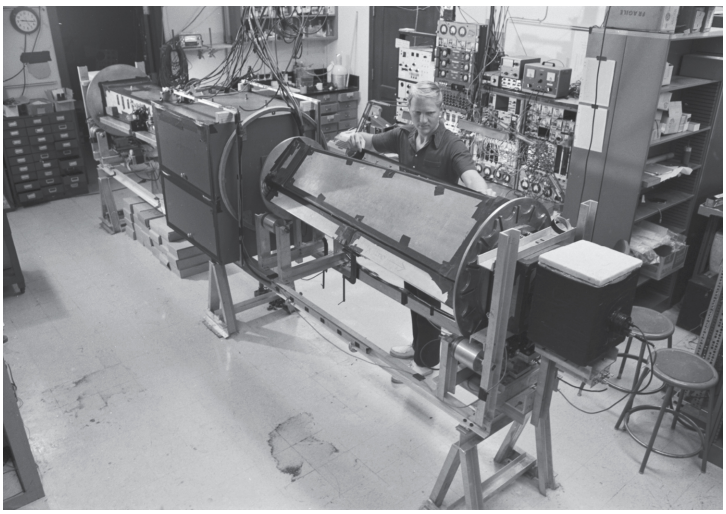


Figure 9.2. John Clauser and one of his Bell experiments in Berkeley, 1975.

Shortly before Dieter Zeh's paper on decoherence was published in 1970, he received an invitation to speak at a summer school on the foundations of quantum physics, sponsored by the Italian Physical Society. Strangely, this summer school had its origins in the political and cultural tumult that had swept the world in 1968. Left-wing Italian physicists, generally younger, had been agitating for a reevaluation of the relationship between physics and the wider world, the social responsibilities of physicists, and the philosophical foundations of physics itself. The older, more conservative Italian physicists were uninterested in upsetting the status quo. With the society on the brink of splitting entirely, the board accepted the proposal to hold a summer school in Varenna on the foundations of quantum physics. They invited the French physicist Bernard d'Espagnat, a former student of de Broglie's and a colleague of Bell's at CERN, to organize the school, and, in turn, Wigner had suggested inviting Zeh to d'Espagnat.

The 1970 Varenna summer school was later dubbed "the Woodstock of quantum dissidents," and with good reason. The speakers, aside from Zeh, included David Bohm, Louis de Broglie, Eugene Wigner, Abner Shimony, Josef Jauch, Bryce DeWitt, and John Bell himself. "When I arrived at